

Where the Bishop is, there let the multitude of believers be;
even as where Jesus is, there is the Catholic Church" Ignatius of Antioch, 1st c. A.D

Holy Cards



They are such a distinctive part of the Catholic "visual culture" -- inexpensive images that we use as bookmarks and keep in picture frames, slip inside Christmas and greeting cards, keep in our wallets, give to our Godchildren and those we serve in the Church for their special occasions... We keep ones with relevant prayers and images on them to hand out to friends who are going through a hard time, and order special funeral cards ("memorial cards") inscribed with the name and dates of birth and death of a person. Nowadays, one can buy customized holy cards inscribed with personal names and dates as keepsakes for baptisms, First Communions, Confirmations, etc. In Catholic culture, holy cards are ubiquitous and have been for a long time.

The oldest holy card -- a wood block print of St. Christopher -- dates to 1423. In that century, hand-cut and die-cut paper lace came extremely popular and were known as *dévotives dentelles* in France, and as *Andachtsbilden* in Germany.

Holy cards developed when a German, Aloys Senefelder (1771-1834), developed lithography, an inexpensive way of making graphics. In the 1840s, French companies in Paris in the area of the Church of St. Sulpice began mass-producing holy card designs characterized by soft and feminine-looking images, a style that became known as "St. Sulpice Art" ("l'art St. Sulpice"). While many of these cards were sold in America, other companies, such as Carl Benziger and Sons (later the Benziger Company), a Swiss company in operation since 1792, opened branches in America. Nowadays, the best and most commonly-produced holy cards are produced by the Bonella Brothers company, based in Milan, Italy.

One can buy paper cards, laminated cards (they last much longer), cards imprinted with traditional art and icons, and tacky modern holy cards. They generally cost between 30¢ and \$2.00 and can be bought at most Catholic bookstores and giftshops.

Note: See [The Three Hearts](#) page to learn about the symbolism of the graphic at the top of this page.

Holy card

- [Article](#)
- [Talk](#)
- [Read](#)
- [Edit](#)
- [View history](#)

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Appearance

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Text

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Small
Standard
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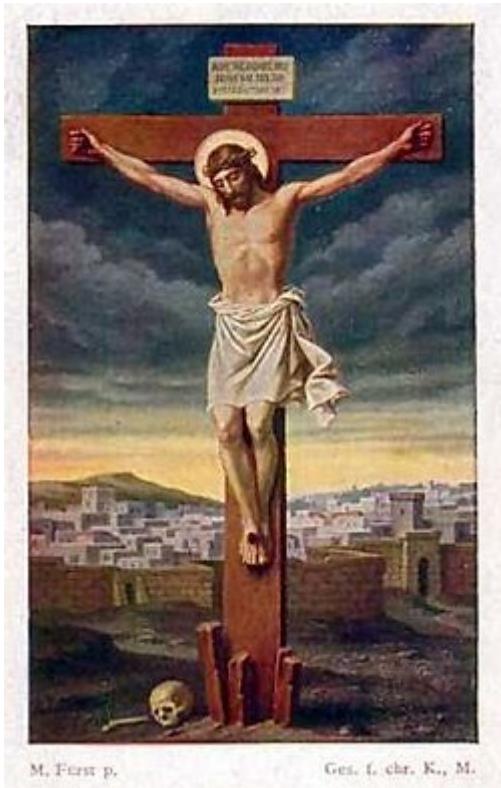
Standard
Wide

Color

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Automatic
Light
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From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia
Not to be confused with [Mass card](#).



A German holy card (c. 1910) depicting the [crucifixion of](#)

[Jesus](#)

In the [Christian](#) tradition, **holy cards** or **prayer cards** are small, [devotional](#) pictures for the use of the faithful that usually depict a religious scene or a [saint](#) in an image about the size of a [playing card](#). The reverse typically contains a [prayer](#), some of which promise an [indulgence](#) for its recitation.

The circulation of these cards is an important part of the visual [folk culture](#) of Roman Catholics, and in modern times, prayer cards have also become popular among Orthodox Christians and Protestant Christians, although with the latter, biblical themes are emphasized within them.^{[1][2]}

Uses



Nuestra Señora de la Soledad de Porta Vaga
Patrona de la Provincia de Caceres y Cabo Verde

Prayer card of [Our Lady of Solitude of Porta Vaga](#) from the

Philippines

Most cards are circulated to assist the [veneration](#) of the saints and images they bear.

Special holy cards are printed for Catholics to be distributed at funerals by the family of the deceased that include the name and usually dates of birth and death of the deceased. These are a particular type of the [in memoriam cards](#), which can also record other events such as [baptisms](#), [confirmations](#), [ordinations](#), or the making of [religious vows](#).

At the end of the nineteenth century, some Protestants also produced similar images of their own. They produced "Bible cards" or "[Sunday school cards](#)", with lithographed illustrations depicting [Bible stories](#) and [parables](#), more modern scenes of religious life or prayer, or sometimes just a Biblical text illuminated by [calligraphy](#); these were linked to Biblical passages that related to the image. The reverse typically held a [sermonette](#) instead of a prayer. Imagery here was always the servant of text, and as such these Protestant cards tended to be replaced by [tracts](#) that emphasized message instead of imagery, and were illustrated with [cartoon-like](#) images if they were illustrated at all.

History

Old master prints

[Old master prints](#), nearly all on religious subjects, served many of the same functions as holy cards, especially the cheaper [woodcuts](#). One early example depicts [Saint Christopher](#) with hand-colouring and is estimated to originate sometime between 1435 and 1450. It was found as part of the binding of a manuscript of the *Laus Virginis* (1417), which belongs to the [John Rylands Library](#), Manchester.^[3]

Later, [engraving](#) or [etching](#) were more commonly used. Some had elaborate borders of paper [lace](#) surrounding the images; these were called *dévotés dentelles* in France.^[citation needed]

One use of such cards is illustrated in an early 15th-century painting of the Annunciation by [Robert Campin](#), which stages the event in a bourgeois home; above the fireplace, a print of

Christopher carrying the Christ child is tacked to the wall, possibly as a more affordable alternative to a painting.^[4]

Lithography

The invention of [chromolithography](#) made it possible to reproduce coloured images cheaply, leading to a much broader circulation of the cards. An early centre of their manufacture was in the environs of the [Church of St Sulpice](#) in Paris; the lithographed images made there were done in delicate [pastel](#) colours, and proved extremely influential in later designs.

[Belgium](#) and Germany also became centres of the manufacture of holy cards, as did [Italy](#) in the twentieth century. Catholic printing houses (such as [Maison de la Bonne Presse](#) in France and [Ars Sacra](#) in Germany) produced large numbers of cards, and often a single design was printed by different companies in different countries.

Recent history

The 1940 [Head of Christ](#) painting has been printed more than 500 million times, including pocket-sized cards for carrying in a [wallet](#).^[5] In the [World War II](#) era, "millions of cards featuring the Head of Christ were distributed through the USO by the [Salvation Army](#) and the [YMCA](#) to members of the American armed forces stationed overseas."^[6]

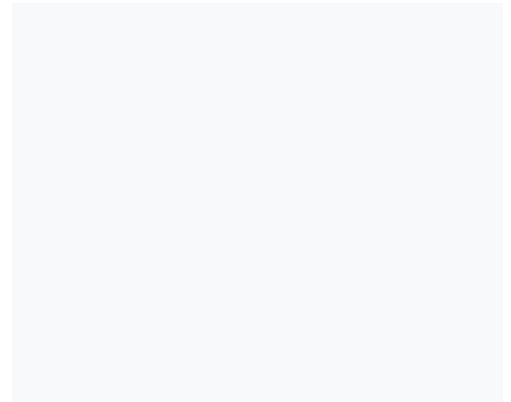
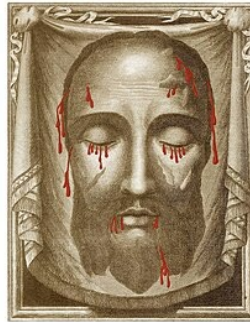
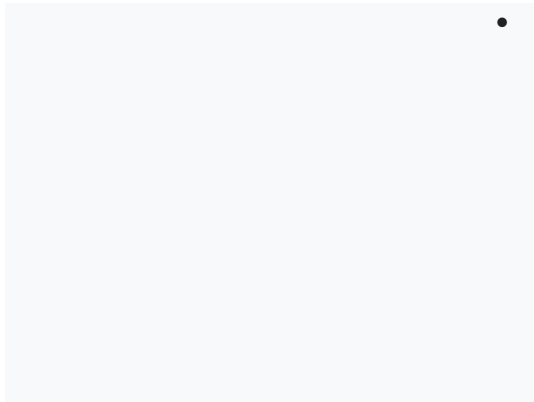
During the [Cold War](#), both Catholics and Protestants helped to popularize these cards, presenting "a united front against the menace of godless Communism".^[7]



Annunciation by Robert Campin; a [wood print](#) is in the top right, between candle fixtures.



Saint [Christopher](#) holy card, c. 1435-1450, [Buxheim](#), with hand-colouring



Prayer card of the [Holy Face of Jesus](#)

Collecting

Holy cards are popular collectible items. They are small and inexpensive and can be stored safely in plastic sleeves in a binder. Holy card collecting is mostly popular in Catholic countries. Some collectors base their collection on various criteria like a favorite saint, country of issue, issuer, etc.

See also

- [Andachtsbilder](#)
- [Icon](#)
- [Saint symbolism](#)

References

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2. Illes, Judika (2011-10-11). *Encyclopedia of Mystics, Saints & Sages*. HarperCollins. p. 68. [ISBN 9780062098542](#). In recent years, holy cards have become increasingly popular among Orthodox Christians as well.
3. ["Early European Print: Saint Christopher"](#). Manchester Digital Collections. Archived from [the original](#) on 2025-07-31. Retrieved 2026-05-31.
4. Verspaandonk, J.A.J.M. (1975). *Het hemels prentenboek: Devotie- en bidprentjes vanaf de 17e eeuw tot het begin van de 20e eeuw (in Dutch)*. Hilversum, Netherlands: Gooi en Sticht. pp. 7–8.
5. Lippy, Charles H. (1 January 1994). [Being Religious, American Style: A History of Popular Religiosity in the United States](#). Greenwood Publishing Group. p. 185. [ISBN 9780313278952](#). Retrieved 30 April 2014. Of these one stands out as having deeply impressed itself of the American religious consciousness: the "Head of Christ" by artist Warner Sallman (1892–1968). Originally sketched in charcoal as a cover illustration for the *Covenant Companion*, the magazine of the Swedish Evangelical Mission Covenant of America denomination, and based on an image of Jesus in a painting by the French artist Leon Augustin Lhermitte, Sallman's "Head of Christ" was painted in 1940. In half a century, it had been produced more than five hundred million times in formats ranging from

large-scale copies for use in churches to wallet-sized ones that individuals could carry with them at all times.

6. Moore, Stephen D. (2001). *God's Beauty Parlor*. Stanford University Press. p. 248. [ISBN 9780804743327](#).
7. Prothero, Stephen (15 December 2003). *American Jesus: How the Son of God Became a National Icon*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux. p. 117. [ISBN 9780374178901](#). During the postwar revival of the 1940s and 1950s, as Protestants and Catholics downplayed denominational differences in order to present a united front against the menace of godless Communism, Sallman's Jesus became far and away the most common image of Jesus in American homes, churches, and workplaces. Thanks to Sallman (and the savvy marketing of his distributors), Jesus became instantly recognizable by Americans of all races and religions.

Further reading

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- Dipasqua, Sandra & Calamari, Barbara (2004). *Holy Cards*. New York: Harry N. Abrams. [ISBN 0-8109-4338-7](#).
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December 25, 2025

Holy Cards and Prayer Cards: Meaning, History, and Modern Funeral Uses

At a wake, a visitation, or the quiet moment when guests begin to file out of a church, there is often a small, ordinary exchange that carries surprising weight. Someone reaches for a card from a basket near the guestbook. Someone else slips one into a coat pocket like a promise they do not want to forget. Later, that same card shows up on a kitchen windowsill, tucked into a Bible, or pressed into the corner of a mirror. This is the gentle power of a **holy card** or **prayer card**: it gives grief something to hold, and it gives memory a place to rest.

If you are planning a Catholic funeral, a Christian memorial service, or even a more flexible gathering that still includes prayer and Scripture, you may be wondering what these cards are “supposed” to be. Are they the same as memorial cards? Do they need a saint image? Is a photo appropriate? And when do you hand them out without it feeling awkward or performative? The answers are simpler than they seem. A **funeral prayer card** is not a test of religious knowledge or a design contest. It is a keepsake meant to comfort the living and honor the dead, in a way that feels natural to your family.

What Holy Cards and Prayer Cards Are

A **holy card** is traditionally a small devotional card—often about the size of a playing card—with a sacred image on the front and a prayer on the back. Many families use the term **prayer card** interchangeably, especially in funeral settings, because the “holy” part is less about the paper and more about the purpose: prayer, remembrance, and spiritual comfort.

When these cards are created for a funeral, they become what many people call a **funeral holy card**, a **funeral prayer card**, or a **religious memorial card**. They usually include the person’s name, dates, and a short prayer or Scripture reference. In Catholic communities, they may also include a saint, Mary, the Sacred Heart, or an image connected to the funeral liturgy. In other Christian traditions, they may lean toward biblical imagery—crosses, doves, landscapes—or a photograph paired with a verse.

What makes them feel “right” is not a single formula. It is whether the card helps people pray, remember, and feel connected—especially after the service, when the house gets quiet and the reality settles in.

Where the Tradition Comes From

Holy cards have a long, surprisingly human history. They began as simple printed images that pilgrims could carry home as a reminder of a shrine visit, a saint’s intercession, or a moment of spiritual clarity. Over time, they became a familiar part of Catholic devotional life—given by priests and religious sisters, traded among children, and saved like family photographs.

According to the National Catholic Register, early holy cards were sold in the Middle Ages as pilgrimage keepsakes, and one of the oldest surviving examples is a St. Christopher woodcut dated to 1423. As printing methods improved, the tradition spread widely, and what began as a “souvenir of faith” gradually became something more personal: a small image and a few words that could be carried through daily life.

In funeral use, that same logic makes sense. Death can make everything feel too large to hold at once—big emotions, big decisions, big questions. A small card offers a manageable anchor. It says, in a quiet way, “This life mattered, and we will keep remembering.”

Why Prayer Cards Still Matter at Funerals Today

Modern funerals look different than they did a generation ago, and not because families care less. In many cases, families are making choices that allow more flexibility—holding a service later, gathering in smaller groups, or creating rituals that fit travel schedules and finances. Cremation is a major driver of that flexibility. According to the **National Funeral Directors Association**, the U.S. cremation rate is projected to be 63.4% in 2025 and is projected to rise substantially by 2045. The **Cremation Association of North America** reports that the U.S. cremation rate was 61.8% in 2024 and projects continued growth in the coming years.

When more families choose cremation, the memorial timeline often changes. Some families do direct cremation first and then plan a Mass or memorial service when relatives can attend. Some hold a small service now and a larger celebration of life later. In all of these scenarios, a **funeral prayer card** becomes even more valuable, because it travels well across time. It can be handed out at the visitation, placed on chairs at the memorial, mailed to out-of-town relatives, or tucked into thank-you notes later. It helps the service remain present in people's lives after the gathering ends.

It can also tie together choices that families increasingly make around **funeral planning**, including how to remember someone in a way that fits everyday life. If you are selecting **cremation urns for ashes**, choosing **keepsake urns** to share among siblings, or deciding whether **keeping ashes at home** feels comforting or heavy, the prayer card can become part of that same story. It is one more way to make remembrance tangible.

How Holy Cards Differ From Memorial Cards and Mass Cards

Families often use these terms interchangeably, and that is understandable—because in real life, they overlap. Still, it can help to name the differences so you can choose what fits your family and your faith tradition without second-guessing yourself.

- **Holy cards** are devotional by nature: a sacred image and a prayer, meant for personal prayer and reflection.
- **Memorial cards** are broader: they may be religious or secular, and often focus on the person's photo, obituary details, and a poem, quote, or verse.
- **Mass cards** are a specific Catholic practice: they indicate that a Mass will be offered for someone (often the deceased). As explained by Our Lady of Good Voyage, a Mass card is a greeting card that lets someone know a person (or a deceased loved one) "will be remembered and prayed for" in the intentions at a Mass.

In practice, a funeral prayer card can function as a holy card and a memorial card at the same time. For Catholic funerals, it is also common for families to receive Mass cards from friends and relatives separately. The key is not to force everything into one card, but to let each element do its job: prayer, remembrance, or a concrete expression of spiritual support.

Common Prayers, Verses, and Wording Families Choose

The most common anxiety families have is whether they will “get the wording right.” In reality, the best **prayer card wording** is simple and faithful to the spirit of the service. You are not writing a theology paper. You are giving people a small companion for the days when grief shows up unexpectedly.

If the funeral is Catholic, many families choose prayers that are familiar and communal—words people already know by heart, or that echo what they heard in the liturgy. If the service is Christian but not Catholic, families often choose a short Scripture reference, a line about comfort and hope, and a prayer that feels consistent with the person’s faith.

Here are a few options that tend to work across many Catholic and Christian services, and that can easily be adapted into a **funeral prayer card template**:

- The “Eternal Rest” prayer (often used at Catholic funerals and during the days that follow).
- Psalm 23 (many families print a reference or a short excerpt rather than the full passage).
- John 14 (a common reading theme about peace and preparing a place).
- The Lord’s Prayer (especially meaningful when prayed together at the service).
- A simple prayer for comfort and gratitude that includes the person’s name.
- A brief line about reunion and hope, paired with a Scripture reference rather than a long quotation.

If you are unsure what is appropriate, the simplest approach is also the most respectful: ask the priest, pastor, or funeral director what they see most often, and what fits the service you are planning. Many families find relief in hearing, “Yes, that is completely appropriate.”

Photo and Design Options That Feel Meaningful

Design choices can feel emotionally loaded, especially when multiple relatives have strong opinions. One person wants a traditional saint image. Another wants a smiling photo “so people remember her that way.” A third feels uneasy about photos, or worries the card will feel like a party favor. In most cases, the path forward is to focus on the card’s purpose: it should be easy to keep, easy to read, and gentle to look at months later.

For Catholic funerals, traditional fronts include images of Jesus, Mary, the Sacred Heart, the Divine Mercy image, a patron saint, or symbols like a cross and lilies. For Christian funerals broadly, design often centers on a cross, a dove, light through clouds, or nature imagery. A photograph can be entirely appropriate in both contexts, especially when it is understated and dignified. If you do choose a photo, families often prefer one where the person looks like themselves—warm, recognizable, not overly posed.

On the back, the layout usually works best when it is simple: name, dates, a short prayer or verse, and (if desired) one line like “In Loving Memory” or “Forever Loved.” If the funeral includes cremation and a memorial service is planned later, some families add a quiet line such as “Memorial Mass to follow” or “Celebration of Life details enclosed,” especially when the service is not immediately tied to a cemetery burial.

And if your family is navigating multiple kinds of memorial decisions at once—cards, programs, an **urn**, and perhaps **keepsakes**—this is where cohesion can be comforting. Some families match the prayer card design style to the memorial display they are creating at home or at the service: a framed photo, candles, flowers, and (if cremation is involved) the urn itself.

Etiquette for Handing Them Out

There is no single “correct” moment to distribute prayer cards, and that is good news. The right timing depends on the flow of your service and what feels natural in your community.

At a wake or visitation, many families place the stack of cards near the guestbook, alongside pens, memorial folders, and perhaps a small sign-in table. People take one as they arrive or as they leave. At a **funeral Mass** or church service, cards are often placed on a table in the narthex, handed out by ushers, or set on chairs before the service begins. For a graveside service, families sometimes give them out at the end, when people are ready to say goodbye and may appreciate a small keepsake to take with them.

If you are concerned about it feeling transactional, a helpful reframe is this: you are not “handing out cards.” You are offering a way for people to continue remembering. If

someone forgets to take one, that is okay. If someone takes an extra for a family member who could not attend, that is also okay. These cards are meant to travel.

As for quantity, a practical rule is to print roughly the number of people you expect, plus a modest buffer. Prayer cards often become keepsakes for grandchildren, godchildren, and relatives who will want one months later. Planning for that reality is not wasteful; it is compassionate.

Prayer Cards in a World Where Cremation Is Common

Even if the funeral is religious, many families today are simultaneously making practical decisions about disposition and long-term memorialization. That is where prayer cards can quietly bridge the spiritual and the practical. They can sit beside an urn at the service. They can be placed in a memory box at home. They can travel with someone who is carrying grief back to another state.

If you are choosing an urn, you may find it helpful to separate the decision into two questions: “Where will the ashes be now?” and “Where will they be later?” Funeral.com’s guide [How to Choose a Cremation Urn That Fits Your Plans](#) walks through that “now and later” thinking in plain language, including how families combine a primary urn with **keepsake urns** when multiple relatives want a portion.

For families who plan to keep the urn at home—either temporarily or long-term—questions about **keeping ashes at home** are common and normal. Funeral.com’s resources [Should You Keep Cremated Ashes at Home?](#) and [Ashes at Home: Safety, Etiquette, and Talking with Family About Long-Term Plans](#) can help you think through placement, family dynamics, and what feels respectful in daily life.

If your family is still deciding **what to do with ashes**, you may be considering options like burial, scattering, a niche, or a ceremony involving water. A **water burial** (or water-based ceremony) can be deeply meaningful for families who feel connected to the ocean, a lake, or a particular shoreline. Funeral.com’s guide [Understanding What Happens During a Water Burial Ceremony](#) explains what families typically do, what biodegradable options are designed for, and how the ritual often unfolds.

And for families balancing meaning with budget, cost clarity matters. If you have found yourself asking **how much does cremation cost**, Funeral.com’s article [How Much Does Cremation Cost? Average Prices and Budget-Friendly Options](#) is a practical companion, especially when you are trying to understand what is included, what is optional, and how memorial items fit into the total.

When families choose cremation, they also often choose more than one form of remembrance. Some keep most ashes in a full-size urn and share a small amount among relatives. That is where **small cremation urns** can feel like a balanced middle: more substantial than a tiny keepsake, but still easy to place in a personal space. Others prefer a set of **keepsake urns** so siblings, adult children, or close friends can each have a portion. And for those who want something wearable and private, **cremation jewelry** is often the most emotionally sustainable choice—something you can carry without having to explain it to anyone.

If that resonates, Funeral.com's guide [Cremation Jewelry 101](#) explains how these pieces work and who they tend to be right for, and you can explore options in **cremation jewelry** and **cremation necklaces**. In a sense, prayer cards and cremation jewelry serve a similar human need: they let remembrance move with you through ordinary life.

Including Pets, Too

Many families planning a funeral are also carrying other, quieter griefs—especially the loss of a beloved pet that happened recently, or that is tightly woven into the person's story. In those moments, it can be comforting to acknowledge that mourning is rarely "one thing at a time." Some families choose to include a line on a prayer card that references a pet waiting "at peace," while others create a separate keepsake card for the pet, especially when children are grieving.

If your family is also navigating choices around pet cremation, the language is often the same language of love: you are deciding **what to do with ashes**, how to create a home memorial, and what feels like a fitting tribute. Funeral.com's guide [Choosing the Right Urn for Pet Ashes](#) walks through sizing and personalization in a gentle, practical way. And if you are browsing options, Funeral.com's collections include **pet cremation urns**, **pet figurine cremation urns**, and **pet keepsake cremation urns**—choices that range from discreet to deeply personal.

A Practical Way to Decide What Your Card Should Be

When families feel stuck, it is usually because they are trying to make the "perfect" card represent an entire life. A more workable approach is to let the card have a smaller job description. The front can offer a peaceful image or a photograph. The back can offer a prayer that people can return to, plus the essential facts that help memory stay anchored in reality.

If your loved one was Catholic, it is completely appropriate for the card to feel Catholic: saints, Mary, and familiar prayers are part of how many families grieve. If your loved one was Christian in a broader sense, it is also appropriate for the card to reflect that

tradition: Scripture references, a cross, and words of comfort that fit the community. If your family is mixed-faith, you can still create a card that welcomes everyone by choosing language focused on love, rest, peace, and gratitude, while keeping the prayer simple and sincere.

And if you are carrying a lot of decisions at once—cards, services, costs, disposition, and the question of what comes next—try to remember that each choice does not have to do everything. Prayer cards can be one calm, steady element in the middle of **funeral planning**. They can sit beside an urn if you choose [cremation urns for ashes](#). They can be tucked into a condolence note. They can be saved by someone who needed a tangible reminder that your loved one's life mattered.

In that way, the card becomes what it has quietly been for centuries: a small window that lets light in, even when the days feel heavy.

What Are Catholic Holy Cards

What Are Catholic Holy Cards

Many of us grew up seeing small, colorful cards tucked into our grandparents' Bibles, slipped behind a crucifix on the wall, or resting quietly in a wallet. We might not have asked much about them at the time, but they were simply "there," part of the gentle fabric of Catholic life. This page looks at what are Catholic holy cards in a simple, down-to-earth way: what they are, how people use them in everyday prayer, and why they still matter in a busy, digital world.

what are Catholic holy cards

I'd like to see

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Understanding What Are Catholic Holy Cards in Daily Life

At the simplest level, Catholic holy cards are small printed images of Jesus, Mary, the saints, or scenes from the Gospels, usually with a short prayer on the back. They are easy to tuck into a pocket, a missal, a journal, or a lunchbox. They are not magic. They are not lucky charms. They are reminders—quiet invitations to remember God, to ask for help, and to feel connected with the Church across time.

When I first tried to explain what are Catholic holy cards to a friend who wasn't familiar with them, I realized how ordinary and yet how personal they really are. One card might bring back memories of a First Communion, another might remind you of a grandparent who used to whisper a short prayer every morning. Little by little, a handful of cards can become a kind of spiritual photo album of your own life with God.

Historically, these small devotional images grew out of a long tradition of sacred art in the Church. If you look up holy cards in Christian tradition, you can see how Christians have used small, portable pictures for centuries. Today, the format is often a simple laminated card, but the idea is old: carry something beautiful and meaningful with you, so that prayer never feels too far away.

What Makes a Holy Card “Catholic”

When you ask what are Catholic holy cards, the “Catholic” part usually shows up in a few simple ways:

Images of Jesus, Mary, or the saints specially honored in the Catholic Church.

Prayers that come from Catholic devotion, such as the Hail Mary, the Memorare, or short novena prayers.

References to sacraments, feast days, or traditional Catholic practices, like the Sacred Heart or Divine Mercy.

Holy cards do not replace the Mass, the sacraments, or Scripture. They simply point toward them. A card with the Sacred Heart might gently nudge you to go to confession. A card with the Infant Jesus might draw your mind to Christmas in the middle of a stressful June afternoon. They work more like gentle taps on the shoulder than big dramatic moments.

Common Types of Catholic Holy Cards

If you browse a set of holy cards, you’ll notice a few patterns. Even though the art styles differ—some are very detailed and old-fashioned, others more modern—the themes are surprisingly steady.

1. Jesus-Centered Holy Cards

Many holy cards focus on Jesus Himself: the Sacred Heart, the Good Shepherd, the Divine Mercy image, the Child Jesus, or scenes from His life like the Nativity or the Last Supper. These cards often carry prayers of trust, mercy, or surrender. Some people keep a Divine Mercy card near their desk, so that in a moment of anxiety they can just glance up and quietly say, “Jesus, I trust in You.”

what are Catholic holy cards Let me look closer

2. Marian Holy Cards

Cards of Mary—Our Lady of Guadalupe, Our Lady of Lourdes, Our Lady of Fatima, the Immaculate Heart—are among the most common. They often accompany very simple prayers: “Mary, be with me today,” or a short version of the Hail Mary. I still keep a worn card of Our Lady of Guadalupe that someone slipped into my hand after a difficult confession years ago. The corners are bent and the color has faded, but it reminds me that I am not walking alone.

what are Catholic holy cards This looks familiar

3. Saints and Patrons

Many people first learn what are Catholic holy cards at a Confirmation or a First Communion, when they receive a card with a specific saint. Saint Thérèse, Saint Joseph, Saint Anthony, Saint Pio, and many others are regularly printed on cards with a short prayer on the back. These are not about “collecting” saints, but about having a small reminder of someone in heaven whose faith can encourage you.

what are Catholic holy cards I might keep this

4. Prayer Cards for Special Moments

Some holy cards are created for very specific occasions: funerals, anniversaries, ordinations, or parish missions. A memorial card from a funeral, for example, usually includes a picture of a saint or of Jesus, plus the name and dates of the person who has died. Many people tuck these into their Bible or on a small home altar, and they naturally pray for the person whenever their eyes land on the card.

How Holy Cards Fit into Everyday Catholic Life

Once you understand what are Catholic holy cards in theory, the next question is how they actually live in a regular day. There is no “right” way, just many small, steady possibilities.

1. In a Wallet or Purse

Keeping a holy card in a wallet means it goes where you go: the grocery store, the gas station, the office. You might only see it when you open your wallet to pay for something, but that tiny glance can become a habit: “Lord, thank You for providing,” or “Saint Joseph, help me use money wisely.” The card simply anchors that intention.

2. In a Prayer Corner or by the Bed

Many Catholic homes have a small prayer corner—maybe a crucifix, a candle, a rosary, and a few holy cards propped up against a framed picture. At night, when you’re tired and words feel hard, those images can help you pray just by looking. Sometimes I just sit and let my eyes move from one card to another: Jesus, Mary, a saint I love. No big speech, just presence.

what are Catholic holy cards This could fit here

3. In Books, Journals, and Missals

Many people use holy cards as bookmarks. Sliding a card into a Bible or a spiritual book makes it easy to pause and pray at the same time. Some cards have specific prayers for trust, patience, or strength. Seeing those words when you open your book can be a simple reminder to bring whatever you’re reading into conversation with God.

4. Shared Quietly with Others

A very gentle way Catholics share faith is by quietly passing along a holy card. There is something humble about it. No lecture, no pressure, just a card and maybe a sentence like, “I thought you might like this prayer.” When my mother slipped a small card of Saint Joseph the Worker into my hand when I was worried about my job, it didn’t fix everything, but it helped me feel seen—by her and by God.

Personal Experiences with Holy Cards

When I reflect on what are Catholic holy cards in my own life, a few memories stand out more than the rest. None of them are dramatic. They are quiet, almost ordinary moments that became small turning points.

Years ago, I kept a simple card of the Sacred Heart in the front of my journal. I was going through a season of feeling scattered and a little numb in prayer. Most days I would just open the journal, stare at that image, and say nothing. Over time, the card became worn at the edges, but looking at it each day slowly softened my heart. Nothing flashy, just a gentle reminder that I was not alone, even when I didn’t have the right words.

what are Catholic holy cards This feels familiar

Another time, after a funeral, I brought home a memorial holy card with the image of the Risen Christ. I wasn’t especially close to the person who had died, but for some reason I kept that card on my bedside table. On nights when I couldn’t sleep, I would just look at it and quietly say, “Lord, receive them, and help me trust You.” That little card slowly linked my memory of that funeral to the bigger hope of the Resurrection, without big speeches or heavy emotions.

Experiences like these are why it's hard for me to talk about what are Catholic holy cards as if they were just "religious products." For many of us, they become gentle companions—small, sturdy, and present for years at a time. They don't fix life, but they quietly walk with us through it.

Choosing Holy Cards with Intention

If you're just beginning to understand what are Catholic holy cards and you feel drawn to having a few, it can help to choose with intention rather than just collecting a large stack. A handful used well is often better than a box that gathers dust.

Start with Jesus. A card showing the Sacred Heart, the Divine Mercy, or Jesus the Good Shepherd can become a daily focal point. Let your eyes rest there, even for a few seconds, before you rush into the day.

Add Mary. Many Catholics find peace in simply looking at an image of Mary and asking her to pray with them. An image you genuinely like is better than one that feels "forced."

Choose one or two saints. Instead of trying to cover every saint, start with one or two who quietly draw your heart. Maybe a patron of your work, your parish, or your family's heritage.

Think about where they will live. A card for your wallet might be different from a card for your nightstand or your office desk. The setting can shape the kind of prayer you naturally make.

The point is not to own the "right" card, but to let these small images serve your relationship with God. If a card stops helping you pray, you can gently retire it, pass it to someone else, or keep it in a box for later.

what are Catholic holy cards Maybe these could help

Caring for Holy Cards with Respect

When you grasp what are Catholic holy cards in a deeper way, questions about care and respect naturally follow. Since they bear sacred images, we try not to treat them like trash. They aren't idols, but they do represent holy realities.

Many people keep old or extra holy cards in a small box or envelope rather than letting them scatter. If a card becomes too damaged to use, some Catholics bring it to a parish to be burned respectfully or buried, similar to how blessed objects are treated. If that's not possible, you can still handle it gently, with a simple prayer of thanks before letting it go.

In daily use, caring for holy cards is usually very simple: avoiding leaving them where they'll get stepped on, written over, or stained; keeping them in a Bible or wallet pocket; maybe laminating especially meaningful ones so they last longer. The care we show them quietly reflects the care we want to show toward God and the saints.

what are Catholic holy cards I'd like something like this

FAQ About What Are Catholic Holy Cards

1. Are Catholic holy cards just decorations?

No. While they can be beautiful, holy cards are mainly meant to support prayer. They help you remember God, the saints, and the mysteries of the faith in the middle of everyday life. You can certainly enjoy the art, but the deeper purpose is to draw your heart gently toward God, even if only for a moment.

2. Do I have to pray a specific way with a holy card?

There is no single right way to pray with a holy card. Many people simply look at the image in silence, or read the short prayer on the back slowly. Others keep the card nearby and glance at it through the day, turning that small moment into a brief, honest prayer. The important thing is sincerity, not technique.

3. Is it okay to carry holy cards in my wallet or bag?

Yes. Many Catholics keep one or two cards in a wallet or purse. The goal is not to “protect” the card from every crease, but to treat it with reasonable respect. If it wears out over time, that simply shows it was part of your daily life. You can replace it, or keep the worn one in a safe spot if it has special meaning.

4. Can I give holy cards to friends or family who are struggling?

Yes, if it feels appropriate and respectful. A quiet gift of a holy card—perhaps with a simple note like “I’m praying for you”—can be a gentle sign of care. It should never feel like pressure or a lecture. Let the card speak softly on its own, and leave the rest to God.

5. How many holy cards should I have?

There is no rule. Some people have just one or two that they keep for decades. Others end up with a small collection over the years, especially from sacraments and funerals. What matters more than the number is how they help you pray. If a few well-chosen cards quietly support your relationship with God, then they are serving their purpose.

In the [Christian](#) tradition, **holy cards** or **prayer cards** are small, [devotional](#) pictures for the use of the faithful that usually depict a religious scene or a [saint](#) in an image about the size of a [playing card](#). The reverse typically contains a [prayer](#), some of which promise an [indulgence](#) for its recitation.

The circulation of these cards is an important part of the visual [folk culture](#) of Roman Catholics, and in modern times, prayer cards have also become popular among Orthodox Christians and Protestant Christians, although with the latter, biblical themes are emphasized within them.^{[\[1\]](#)[\[2\]](#)}

Uses

Prayer card of [Our Lady of Solitude of Porta Vaga](#) from the Philippines

Most cards are circulated to assist the [veneration](#) of the saints and images they bear.

Special holy cards are printed for Catholics to be distributed at funerals by the family of the deceased that include the name and usually dates of birth and death of the deceased. These are a particular type of the [in memoriam cards](#), which can also record other events such as [baptisms](#), [confirmations](#), [ordinations](#), or the making of [religious vows](#).

At the end of the nineteenth century, some Protestants also produced similar images of their own. They produced "Bible cards" or "[Sunday school](#) cards", with lithographed illustrations depicting [Bible stories](#) and [parables](#), more modern scenes of religious life or prayer, or sometimes just a Biblical text illuminated by [calligraphy](#); these were linked to Biblical passages that related to the image. The reverse typically held a [sermonette](#) instead of a prayer. Imagery here was always the servant of text, and as such these Protestant cards tended to be replaced by [tracts](#) that emphasized message instead of imagery, and were illustrated with [cartoon](#)-like images if they were illustrated at all.

History

Old master prints

[Old master prints](#), nearly all on religious subjects, served many of the same functions as holy cards, especially the cheaper [woodcuts](#). One early example depicts [Saint Christopher](#) with hand-colouring and is estimated to originate sometime between 1435 and 1450. It was found as part of the binding of a manuscript of the *Laus Virginis* (1417), which belongs to the [John Rylands Library](#), Manchester.^[3]

Later, [engraving](#) or [etching](#) were more commonly used. Some had elaborate borders of paper [lace](#) surrounding the images; these were called *dévotives dentelles* in France.^[citation needed]

One use of such cards is illustrated in an early 15th-century painting of the Annunciation by [Robert Campin](#), which stages the event in a bourgeois home; above the fireplace, a print of Christopher carrying the Christ child is tacked to the wall, possibly as a more affordable alternative to a painting.^[4]

Lithography

The invention of [chromolithography](#) made it possible to reproduce coloured images cheaply, leading to a much broader circulation of the cards. An early centre of their manufacture was in the environs of the [Church of St Sulpice](#) in Paris; the lithographed images made there were done in delicate [pastel](#) colours, and proved extremely influential in later designs.

[Belgium](#) and Germany also became centres of the manufacture of holy cards, as did [Italy](#) in the twentieth century. Catholic printing houses (such as [Maison de la Bonne Presse](#) in France and [Ars Sacra](#) in Germany) produced large numbers of cards, and often a single design was printed by different companies in different countries.

Recent history

The 1940 [Head of Christ](#) painting has been printed more than 500 million times, including pocket-sized cards for carrying in a [wallet](#).^[5] In the [World War II](#) era, "millions of cards featuring the Head of Christ were distributed through the USO by the [Salvation Army](#) and the [YMCA](#) to members of the American armed forces stationed overseas."^[6]

During the [Cold War](#), both Catholics and Protestants helped to popularize these cards, presenting "a united front against the menace of godless Communism".^[7]

- *Annunciation* by Robert Campin; a [wood print](#) is in the top right, between candle fixtures.



• Saint [Christopher](#) holy card, c. 1435-1450, [Buxheim](#), with hand-colouring

• Prayer card of the [Holy Face of Jesus](#)
undefined

Collecting

Holy cards are popular collectible items. They are small and inexpensive and can be stored safely in plastic sleeves in a binder. Holy card collecting is mostly popular in Catholic countries. Some collectors base their collection on various criteria like a favorite saint, country of issue, issuer, etc.

See also

- [Andachtsbilder](#)
- [Icon](#)
- [Saint symbolism](#)

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2. [↑](#) Illes, Judika (2011-10-11). *Encyclopedia of Mystics, Saints & Sages*. HarperCollins. p. 68. [ISBN 9780062098542](#). In recent years, holy cards have become increasingly popular among Orthodox Christians as well.
3. [↑](#) "[Early European Print: Saint Christopher](#)". Manchester Digital Collections. Archived from [the original](#) on 2025-07-31. Retrieved 2026-05-31.
4. [↑](#) Verspaandonk, J.A.J.M. (1975). *Het hemels prentenboek: Devotie- en bidprentjes vanaf de 17e eeuw tot het begin van de 20e eeuw (in Dutch)*. Hilversum, Netherlands: Gooi en Sticht. pp. 7–8.
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one stands out as having deeply impressed itself of the American religious consciousness: the "Head of Christ" by artist Warner Sallman (1892–1968). Originally sketched in charcoal as a cover illustration for the *Covenant Companion*, the magazine of the Swedish Evangelical Mission Covenant of America denomination, and based on an image of Jesus in a painting by the French artist Leon Augustin Lhermitte, Sallman's "Head of Christ" was painted in 1940. In half a century, it had been produced more than five hundred million times in formats ranging from large-scale copies for use in churches to wallet-sized ones that individuals could carry with them at all times.

6. [↑](#) Moore, Stephen D. (2001). *God's Beauty Parlor*. Stanford University Press. p. 248. [ISBN 9780804743327](#).
7. [↑](#) Prothero, Stephen (15 December 2003). *American Jesus: How the Son of God Became a National Icon*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux. p. 117. [ISBN 9780374178901](#). During the postwar revival of the 1940s and 1950s, as Protestants and Catholics downplayed denominational differences in order to present a united front against the menace of godless Communism, Sallman's Jesus became far and away the most common image of Jesus in American homes, churches, and workplaces. Thanks to Sallman (and the savvy marketing of his distributors), Jesus became instantly recognizable by Americans of all races and religions.

Further reading

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The History Behind Holy Cards



By [Michael Cunningham](#)

April 26, 2021 • [View profile](#) • Share



Pocket-sized images of religious figures, known as Holy Cards, first appeared in the 1400s. The earliest known card is from 1423, probably from southern Germany, and depicts Saint Christopher, with hand coloring. These cards, which were created to be carried around or simply displayed in a person's home, allowed everyday people to bring saints and other religious figures in to their day-to-day lives.

Unlike other sacred imagery at the time, which was expensive and tended to be confined to the wealthy or religious, these cards allowed the average person to establish a personal connection with a saint. The cards were inexpensive and disposable, and their value came more from a person's connection to the saint and the meaning they imposed on that relationship, rather than from the price of the card itself.

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Prior to the emergence of Holy Cards, religious imagery had been out of reach of the majority of devout Catholics, but these cards brought the saints to the people in a tangible way. The common people could obtain a Holy Card and keep it with them. Many Holy Cards would have a picture of a Saint on one side and a prayer on the other side. This way Holy Cards were carried with a person and taken out to pray.

The cards helped the faithful to develop devotions to particular saints, and, due to their popularity, a large industry sprang up for the printing and distribution of the cards. They can be used as devotional aids, and as a portable example of how to model one's life after that of a particular saint. Although the style of Holy Cards has changed through the years, their purpose—devotional reminder; commemorative memorial; the story of a saint—has not.

The first Holy Cards were a great way to help educate the faithful on different aspects of the Church. They could have a beautiful picture on one side and prayer or Litany on the other side. These were mass-produced and

would cost very little. Every priest would bless the cards for their congregation and in return, everyone would carry them and use them.

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The printing of holy cards originated with the development of the process of woodcutting, around 1400. These early woodcuts were usually simple religious images with symbols easily recognized by the pilgrims who purchased them. Some of these wood carvings were masterpieces of art themselves. Woodcuts get their name from the way the image is produced: the negative space around the desired image was literally cutaway on a block of wood. This is known as a relief process, as the image sits on the surface, or relief, of the block. Ink is then applied to the raised surface. Once ample pressure is applied, the image is transferred from the block to the paper. In essence, the ink would be applied to the block of wood and then the woodblock would be pressed on paper. The invention of the printing press in the mid 15th century allowed for faster reproduction of woodcut prints. It also allowed for standardization and a uniform process of making the card. The card stock changed as well too. The cards were small enough so they could be carried and large enough so they could be read easily.

As wood carving became less and less popular, many people turned to metals such as copper to make decorative cards. Because of the durability of paper and the need for a great many cards- the paper Holy Card was used and regained its popularity in the late 19th and early 20th centuries.

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In the days when Bibles were very hard to get, had to be made by hand, Liturgy Books were next to impossible to get, Holy Cards were relatively easy to reproduce and served an important part in both daily Liturgy (Mass) and daily prayer life. Now, as attendance at Church has fallen, many of the younger generation are not attending Church as regularly as their parents and grandparents did- some may ask: What will happen to Holy Cards?

Holy Cards will be around, they will be collected, and they will be admired. It is an art that we can all share and experience. It is an art that is truly living. It is an art that you can put your hands on without worrying about ruining the art. What is a Holy Card? It is a piece of heaven here on earth. It is a copy of a masterpiece meant for the masses and it helped bring religion to the masses. In an age when things were hard to mass-produce- Holy Cards left their mark.

Today let us honor the place these Holy Cards deserve in our hearts. Go to your Church, ask your priest for some Holy Cards. Take two of each card. Get them all blessed. After the blessing take the cards home. Put one each in a Ziplock Bag and save them. Put the other one in your purse or wallet or put it inside of the front visor on the driver's side of the car. Take it out every time you start your car. Remember, start your car and start your day with a prayer- how easy is this to do? It is simple and enjoyable. Learn to use your cards and more importantly, learn to enjoy the artwork of the Church along with the rich doctrines of the Church. Holy Cards- a little bit of Heaven here on earth.

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The Holy Cards That Shaped Saints — and One Family’s Mission to Preserve Them



Inset: After acquiring an original card, Lisa Pellegrini carefully restores tears, fading and discoloration while preserving the character of the original engraving, such as this one inspired by St. Thérèse. (photo: Card courtesy of Lisa Pellegrini; St. Thérèse background image, public domain)

What began as a homeschool curiosity has grown into a family-run printing press dedicated to preserving sacred imagery.

[*Gigi Duncan*, June 19, 2026 – *National Catholic Register*](#)

When St. Thérèse of Lisieux was a child, one holy card captivated her so deeply that she later credited it with inspiring the title by which the world now knows her: “Little Flower.”

The card, titled *La Petit Fleur du Divin Prisonnier* (“The Little Flower of the Divine Prisoner”), depicts Christ crowned with thorns behind prison bars, reaching toward a small flower blooming outside the cell. Intended as a meditation of Christ’s presence in the Blessed Sacrament, the image remained fixed in the mind of the future saint for years.

For Lisa Pellegrini, founder of [Catholic Printing Press](#) in rural Michigan, the card represents something larger than a rarity from another era.

“These cards were the formation of the saints,” Pellegrini told the Register. “Most people couldn’t afford books back then, and that’s why the holy cards were made.”

While Pellegrini does not possess the exact card that passed through Thérèse’s hands, her collection includes examples from the same devotional tradition and printing houses that shaped the young saint’s imagination.

Through Catholic Printing Press and its contemplative art publication, [Immagini Sacre](#) — a magazine dedicated to devotional imagery and forgotten traditions — Pellegrini has spent nearly a decade collecting, restoring and reproducing religious artwork she believes much of the modern world has forgotten.

According to Pellegrini, much of that work stems from a deep devotion to St. Thérèse.

In Chapter Four of *Story of a Soul*, Thérèse reflected on the impact sacred images had on her as a child after one of her sisters introduced her to devotional pictures and holy cards:

“So far I have not said anything about my love for pictures and books, and yet I owe some of the happiest and strongest impressions which have encouraged me in the practice of virtue to the beautiful pictures Pauline used to show me. Everything was forgotten while looking at them.”

Of *La Petit Fleur du Divin Prisonnier*, Thérèse later recalled that the image “suggested so many thoughts that I would remain gazing at it in a kind of ecstasy.”



JESUS

Eh! bien, c'est dans la FOI... c'est dans une FOI NUL...
Que ma main planterait cette petite fleur...
Qui vivrait pour MOI SEUL... des hommes inconnus...
N'aurait d'autre Soleil qu'un regard de mon cœur...

A cette tendre fleur, je voudrais pour Racer...
Cette espérance en moi qui jamais ne faiblit...
Espérance infinie en ma Bonté divine...
Abandon de l'enfant qui sait qu'on le chérit...
Pour l'âge, il lui faudrait sans desir et sans crainte...
Un tranquille, un joyeux, un prompt acquiescement...
Au plus léger appel de ma volonté sainte...
Sans hésitation... sans nul raisonnement...
Elle me ravirait, si prenant pour Feuilleage...
Le mépris de l'estime et des regards humains...
Elle savait voiler à l'œil qui l'enviseage...
Les dons qu'elle a reçus de mes doctes mains...

Je lui voudrais pour Fleur une constante joie...
Que ne pourraient troubler ni revers, ni douleur...
Qui même à la souffrance à l'amertume en proie...
Saurait se réjouir encor de mon bonheur...

Son Fruit enfin serait cette vertu si pure...
Qui ne voit que DIEU SEUL... ici-bas comme aux cieux...
Qui n'a plus de regard pour nulle créature...
Qui ne cherche qu'en MOI le terme de ses vœux...
Par là de mes desseins réalisant l'attente...
Elle aura mérité la plus douce faveur...
Et sur mon cœur sacré greffant mon humble plante...
En l'unissant à MOI, je serai son bonheur...



LA PETITE FLEUR DU DIVIN PRISONNIER

... Hélas! puisque à vous fuir ils s'obstinent sans cesse...
Puisqu'ils vous laissent seul... O le Dieu de mon cœur!
Abaissez par pitié les yeux sur ma bassesse...
Je serai, mon Jésus, votre petite fleur.....

The holy card 'La Petit Fleur Du Divin Prisonnier' ('The Little Flower of the Divine Prisoner') depicts Christ crowned with thorns behind prison bars, reaching toward a small flower blooming outside the cell. (Photo: Courtesy of Lisa Pellegrini)

Eventually, she came to identify herself as that flower.

"I offered myself to Our Lord to be His Little Flower," she wrote. "I longed to console Him, to draw as near as possible to the Tabernacle, to be looked on, cared for, and gathered by Him."

For Pellegrini, the card illustrates the role sacred imagery once played in Catholic devotional life. "These images taught people how to pray," she said.

'Zélie, I Need Your Help'

Pellegrini's fascination with antique holy cards began around 2014 while researching materials for her children's homeschool curriculum.

A former hospice nurse assistant, Pellegrini and her husband Jason now operate the family's heritage Michigan farm while raising their seven children and balancing the work of Catholic Printing Press.



Pellegrini Farms has operated a pick-your-own strawberry market, serving its local community since the 1960s. (Photo: Courtesy of Lisa Pellegrini)

"I'm just a farmer's wife," Pellegrini said. "And in discovering these holy cards and the contemplative journey they brought me on, it was a way of discovering Christ in a new light."

As the family had been consecrated and [enthroned](#) to the Sacred Heart of Jesus, Pellegrini became especially interested in traditional [Sacred Heart badges](#) and détentes — fabric devotional emblems often produced with intricate lace-like borders and textile work.

Though she had some experience crocheting, she had little idea how such objects were made. Seeking help, she turned to asking for the intercession of St. Zélie Martin — the mother of St. Thérèse and a lacemaker by trade.

"I said, 'Zélie, I need your help,'" she recalled.

What began as a personal interest soon became a yearslong effort to recover devotional art that had largely disappeared from public view.

Around 2015, she began posting antique holy card images [online](#). Interest arrived quickly from Catholics around the world. One of the first people to contact her was a Carmelite hermit in Pennsylvania who asked whether she could reproduce her détentes.

At the time, reproducing traditional lace holy cards seemed nearly impossible. But Pellegrini continued experimenting with old techniques and materials.

"We were discouraged a lot at first," she said, "but we just kept working and trying to figure out a way to do it."



A Sacred Heart détente depicts Jesus' Sacred Heart surrounded by eight white roses, symbolizing eternal love. (Photo: Courtesy of Lisa Pellegrini)

Recovering a Lost Visual Language

Today, Pellegrini works with antique dealers, auction houses and collectors throughout Europe in search of rare devotional images hidden away in private collections and forgotten family archives.

"I've been studying the holy cards long enough to know what printing house they came from and which Parisian house had that specific image," she noted.

One collection that especially captured Pellegrini's interest was a 19th-century series of holy cards known as the "[Divine Pilot](#)," originally produced by the Parisian Letaille Printing House. The [series](#) portrays Christ as a nautical pilot guiding souls through the storms and dangers of earthly life, with each card forming part of a larger devotional narrative.



The 'Divine Pilot' issue of 'Immagini Sacre' centers on a series of holy cards portraying Christ guiding souls through the storms and dangers of earthly life. (Photo: Courtesy of Lisa Pellegrini)

After years of searching, Pellegrini believes her family may possess the only complete known set of the original 13-card series.

"I didn't even realize they were a series at first," she said. "I just thought they were worth preserving."

Many of the cards, Pellegrini explained, effectively vanished from public view after older European printing houses closed and devotional customs changed.

"They were hidden away in people's breviaries for years," she said.

Once an original card is acquired, Pellegrini carefully restores it digitally, repairing tears, fading or discoloration while preserving the character of the original engraving. Some restoration and coloring work is

completed with assistance from her children, and the images are ultimately reproduced using a combination of antique techniques and custom-built equipment.

The project has gradually become a family effort, with several of Pellegrini's children assisting in digital restoration, design and packaging.

That work eventually expanded into *Immagini Sacre*, a contemplative publication dedicated to showcasing antique holy cards alongside translated prayers and devotional reflections. Pellegrini is currently preparing the ninth issue on the "Divine Prisoner" and hopes to publish dozens more.

The project, however, is not simply about preserving antique artwork. Pellegrini believes sacred imagery can redirect attention toward contemplative prayer in a culture increasingly shaped by distraction.

"I think, visually, people are hungry," she said. "They just don't realize they're hungry for the Lord."



Lisa Pellegrini works with antique dealers, auction houses and collectors across Europe to locate rare devotional images. (Photo: Courtesy of Lisa Pellegrini)

Beauty as a Path to Prayer

For Pellegrini, sacred images offer a way of redirecting attention toward contemplation. Others who have encountered her work say beauty itself becomes the first form of contact.

Steve Cunningham, founder of [Sensus Fidelium](#) — a Catholic media apostolate known for its extensive library of traditional Catholic sermons and spiritual resources — said the visual appeal of Pellegrini's work constantly draws attention.

"People aren't attracted to 'ugly,'" Cunningham said. "It's beauty that first draws a person's eyes in."

Pellegrini's holy cards and issues of *Immagini Sacre*, he said, quickly became popular when he distributed them at a Eucharistic congress several years ago.

"People nowadays are drawn to traditional items," he said. "They pick something like *Immagini Sacre* up and ask, 'What is this? How can I learn more?' Then the door to the faith is open."

For some readers, that initial curiosity becomes something deeper. In a testimonial published in a previous issue of *Immagini Sacre*, Tammy VanPembrook described the magazine as a spiritual retreat when travel is not possible.

"I work full time and live in a rural area, making it difficult to get away for a spiritual retreat," she wrote. "When I open a new issue of *Immagini Sacre*, I pray, 'Come Holy Ghost, come as you will, Amen,' and I go on a visual prayer retreat. Every issue is a new prayer experience."

VanPembrook said the "Divine Pilot" issue particularly resonated with her.

"The Divine Pilot took me back to my childhood days, growing up on a lake," she wrote. "As I turned the pages, I traveled through the many storms of my youth, safely returned to port by the Divine Pilot in my older age."

VanPembrook's experience reflects what Father Lawrence Carney of the Diocese of Wichita, Kansas, has long observed about the role sacred imagery can play in drawing people closer to God.

A longtime [promoter of the Holy Face Devotion](#), Father Carney first met Pellegrini while preaching a mission in Michigan. The two have remained friends, and Father Carney frequently offers spiritual counsel as Pellegrini continues developing Catholic Printing Press and *Immagini Sacre*.

"I was immediately struck by the beauty of the holy cards with the lace on them," he said. "The colors were so beautiful. I thought [Lisa] did things in such a tasteful way."

For Father Carney, that beauty serves a deeper purpose in promoting the "true, good and beautiful," emphasizing "a connection" between Pellegrini's efforts and the spirituality he promotes through the [Holy Face](#) — a devotion "especially significant in the life and writings of St. Thérèse."

"It's through the face of Jesus that we're all connected," he said. "Beautiful art, even on cards or linens, can have a profound effect on people of faith."

As a child, Father Carney said, a holy card of Our Lady of Perpetual Help left a lasting impression on him that led him toward his priestly vocation. "Our Lady's eyes appeared to me on that holy card," he said. "In just those few seconds of looking at an image, I felt the face of Mary calling me to the priesthood."

Today, Father Carney sees sacred imagery as one of many ways God continues to draw souls. "Sometimes people are drawn first by beauty," he said, "and that draws them deeper into union with God."

Reflecting on Pellegrini's work, Father Carney said its impact may be greater than she realizes.

"After all," he said, "it was a holy card that brought me to the priesthood."

In that same spirit, Pellegrini's work with Catholic Printing Press continues the same pattern Father Carney described and which St. Thérèse herself knew so well: beauty that first draws the eye and, at times, draws the soul toward God.



[Gigi Duncan](#) is a staff writer for the National Catholic Register based in Washington, D.C.

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